

British Humour

In this lesson, we'll look at the witty yet sometimes confusing topic of British comedy. You'll learn about five key types of British humour: irony, sarcasm, self-deprecation, wit and wordplay (including innuendos and puns). We'll explore each style with fun examples and phrases you can use in your own conversations. Whether you're a beginner or an advanced learner, this guide will help you understand and appreciate the unique charm of British jokes.

Irony

First up we have **irony**. Irony is when something happens that's the opposite of what you'd expect. Like these two examples:



An astronomer who's afraid of the dark.



An absolutely huge dog called Tiny.

There are actually a few different types of irony:

- **Verbal Irony:**

First up, verbal irony. This occurs when someone says the opposite of what they actually mean. Like saying to a friend who just tripped and fell,

“Well, that was graceful!”

Or asking the person who fell,

“Did you have a nice trip?”

‘Trip’ has two meanings here. A trip can be a journey to a place and back again or it can be when you fall over.

- **Situational Irony:**

Next, we have situational irony. This arises when the outcome of a situation is entirely different from what was expected. For instance, a **fire station catching fire** would be a classic case of situational irony.



- **Dramatic Irony:**

And we also have dramatic irony. This is often used in literature and film. It happens when the audience knows something that the characters do not. Think of Romeo and Juliet. The audience knows that Juliet is sleeping while Romeo, on the other hand, does not!



Here's a quick example so you can get a taste of irony in action.

"And here we are, reporting live from sunny Brighton, where it is just perfect BBQ weather..."



Sarcasm

Next, we have **sarcasm**. Sarcasm is when you say the opposite of what you mean to mock or make fun of something or someone. We Brits are famous for our dry sarcasm. It's often difficult to tell if someone is being genuine or sarcastic.

Sarcasm can also be tricky to master, especially for English learners, because it relies on -

- tone of voice
- facial expressions
- context

For instance, if you were to say,

- **“Oh, fantastic! I've just spilt coffee all over my new shirt.”**

Here's another example.

A: And this is my associate, Mr Greene.

B: Ah, it's a pleasure to meet you, Mr Greene. I've definitely heard your name come up from time to time.

C: **Probably, it's quite a common colour.**

If you come across a bit too serious and someone doesn't get your sarcasm, you can say something like,

- **I'm being sarcastic.**

You can usually spot sarcasm by listening for a mismatch between someone's words and their tone of voice. If someone says something positive but their tone is negative or flat, they're probably being sarcastic.



Self-deprecation

Okay, let's move on to **self-deprecation**. Self-deprecation is when you make jokes about yourself and your own faults. British people seem to do this a lot. We don't like to boast or show off. Instead, we might say things like,

- **I'm so bad at cooking, I could burn water!**
- **I look like I got dressed in the dark.**

Making fun of yourself shows you have a good sense of humour and don't take yourself too seriously. Here's a great example!



I thought being a comedian would help my dating chances. Nope, wrong! At this point, I'm thinking about creating a second Instagram account and sliding into my own DMs... sad, really.



Wit

Internet slang for contacting someone privately on social media, typically for romantic reasons.

Now, it's time for a bit of '**wit**' - the art of being quick, clever and funny all at the same time. British people love witty humour. It's a huge compliment if someone says you're witty.

Here are a few examples of witty phrases I've heard recently:

- **I'm not arguing; I'm just explaining why I'm right.**
- **I didn't drop my phone. I was just making sure gravity still works... seems like it does!**

To work on your wittiness, **try practising wordplay** like **puns** (which we will talk about shortly) and **rhymes** and pay special attention to humour in everyday situations - especially in British TV shows and films. Wit is everywhere! And remember, **timing and delivery are everything!**

Here are a couple of classic examples:

- **Dave isn't short; he's just vertically challenged.**
- **I'm not sleeping; I'm just resting my eyes.**



Innuendo

Right, now, it's time to move on to our first section on **wordplay**, which is essentially playing with the multiple meanings of words in a clever way to make people laugh or think.

Innuendo is a type of wordplay that has a hidden meaning that's often rude or sexual. They're everywhere in British humour - on TV, in newspapers and even names of restaurants.

Even when I was a kid, I heard my teacher make a cheeky joke about my dad's "**meat and two veg**." That's an innuendo for a man's private parts! Innuendos are a big part of British comedy.

To identify innuendos, look out for phrases that seem innocent on the surface but could have a naughty double meaning.



Puns

Alright, let's move on to our last section: the **pun** - the king of wordplay! Puns are jokes that use the different possible meanings of a word or the fact that there are words that sound alike but have different meanings.

They're often **groan-worthy**, but we Brits love them nonetheless - even the really bad ones! You'll see a lot of puns in the names of British shops and businesses.

groan-worthy adj /'grəʊn ,wɜːði/ - very bad, boring or embarrassing

We've got a chip shop called "**The Codfather**," a bakery called "**Bread Pitt**" and a greengrocer called "**Planet of the Grapes**."



Puns are everywhere! Listen for words or phrases that sound similar but have been used in a clever or silly way. To make puns yourself, try to think of words that sound alike but have different meanings and work them into a joke.

Here are a few really great ones for you!

- What do you call a dinosaur with an extensive vocabulary? A thesaurus.
- I wondered why the baseball was getting bigger. Then it hit me.
- What do you call a bear with no teeth? A gummy bear.
- Time flies like an arrow. Fruit flies like a banana.
- How do you organise a space party? You planet.





Activity

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. Self-deprecation in British humour involves:
 - a. making fun of others
 - b. making jokes about yourself
 - c. avoiding jokes altogether
2. An innuendo is a type of wordplay that:
 - a. always has an innocent meaning
 - b. is only used in formal situations
 - c. often has a hidden rude or sexual meaning
3. Which phrase is an example of wit?
 - a. "I'm not lazy; I'm in energy-saving mode."
 - b. "I love getting stuck in traffic."
 - c. "It's raining cats and dogs."
4. British people generally like to boast and show off.
 - a. True
 - b. False
5. Which is NOT an important aspect of sarcasm?
 - a. the words used
 - b. tone of voice
 - c. the listener's mood
6. Which of the following is an example of verbal irony?.
 - a. a fire station catching fire
 - b. Saying, "What lovely weather!" during a thunderstorm.
 - c. a character in a film not knowing something the audience knows
7. Irony is when something happens that's the opposite of what you'd expect.
 - a. True
 - b. False
8. Puns are jokes that play on different possible meanings of words or similar-sounding words.
 - a. True
 - b. False

Answers:

1. b 2. c 3. a 4. b 5. c 6. b 7. a 8. a

